

Stereotype Machines

When you think of people from a particular country, what images come to mind?

These mental pictures may actually be visual stereotypes. Stereotypes are common but oversimplified views of people or things. They are not always inherently bad; they may even help us understand the world around us. However, stereotypes can be harmful and can reinforce outdated ideas or lead to discrimination.

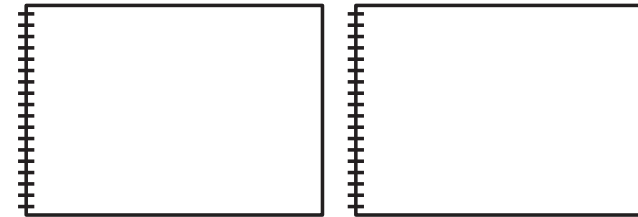
AI in the picture

Today, generative AI tools can convert human 'text prompts' into brand new, AI-generated images. These so-called text-to-image diffusion models generate new pictures of virtually anything by pulling from and combining the vast datasets they were trained on.

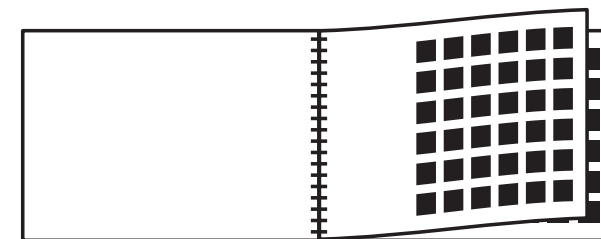
You might assume that images of people generated by AI would be free from stereotypes, because they are created by 'neutral' technology, rather than by humans. But is that true? We experimented with a generative AI model to create images of families and workers from various countries, to see how neutral AI's perceptions are.

The books

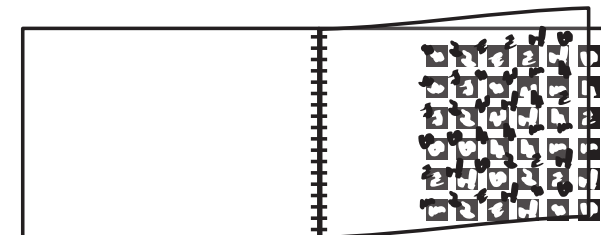
We used the same text prompt to ask an AI text-to-image diffusion model to create images of families and workers.



The two books here contain a selection of 36 AI-generated images of families and workers from five different countries.



Flip through the pages and try to guess which country each set of images is meant to represent. Judge for yourself whether you think the AI-generated images include visual stereotypes or not.



Each book allows you to peel back different layers of the images: first faces; then clothing and objects; then landscapes.

As you remove each layer, observe the repeated elements in each country's set of images. Do these repeated elements constitute stereotypes? Why did AI generate them?

Flip through the books to see whether AI has stereotypes like humans.